

Figure 3.4 *Jam-Firuzkuh: baked brick, plaster-lined cistern at Kuh-i Khara, looking north. From Thomas 2018: fig. 5.24.*

individual tents, and would have been pitched outside established towns and cities.[26] Furthermore, given the Saljuqs' reliance on armies of allied nomadic groups – increasingly true also for the Shansabanis as of the 1150s, if not earlier – vast, open spaces beyond an *urbs* were a necessity as well.

In the end, even though the Shansabanis quite plausibly relied mainly on textile palatial architecture, Firuzkuh's defensive structures, where elite occupation is also in evidence, were still essential: it is possible that the Shansabanis provided the security necessary for the mercantile trade mainly carried out by the region's networks of Jewish communities, who in turn helped to replenish the Shansabanis' (eventually imperial) coffers, forming a politico-economic loop not only increasing the Shansabanis' power but also integrating them further into Firuzkuh's very existence.[27]

MJAP's exploration of the area immediately to the east of the famous *minar* (discussed further in Chapter 4) unearthed an evidently extensive flooring of baked bricks, with two shaft fragments of toppled columns of the same material lying on the southern edge (Figure 3.1). The flooring consisted of varying patterns, ranging from herringbone to large rectangular bricks laid as paving – the column fragments were found atop the latter – strongly hinting at the possibility of a large, columned mosque associated with the *minar*. But MJAP's exploration of the area in five soundings along its northern perimeter (edged by the Hari Rud's southern bank), rather than overall excavation, precluded the collection of many other valuable data – a *lacuna* hopefully to be remedied by future work. In the meanwhile, the paved floor's likely extent and dimensions cannot be determined, nor those of any associated structure. Further, while fragments of a baked-brick wall were found abutting the riverbank delineating the northern wall of the possible mosque, it remains unclear whether a